Ford Motor Company

James P. Vondale, Director
Automotive Safety Office
Environmental & Safety Engineering

September 6, 2002

Mr. Kenneth N. Weinstein
Associate Administrator for Safety Assurance
National Highway Traffic Safety Administration
400 Seventh Street, S.W.
Washington, D.C. 20590

Dear Mr. Weinstein:

Re: Ford Recall No. 02S39 – 2002 Model Year Ford Crown Victoria Natural Gas Vehicles – T-Fitting

Summary

- Ford Action – Ford is conducting a voluntary safety recall involving 2002 Model Year Ford Crown Victoria Natural Gas Vehicles built from May 10, 2001 through March 22, 2002 due to a T-fitting connecting the #3 and #4 natural gas tanks that could potentially leak.

- Number of Vehicles Involved – Approximately 598 vehicles (574 in the United States and 24 in Canada.)

- Affect on Vehicle Operation – In the affected vehicles, there is the potential for a leak from the T-fitting connecting the #3 and #4 natural gas tanks when the natural gas solenoid valves are energized (ignition key in "on" position and engine running) or when refueling, although there have been no reported occurrences of leaks during refueling. If the T-fitting develops a leak, the natural gas would vent to the vapor box that directs vapors through a vent tube outside of the vehicle trunk space and passenger compartment. The natural gas leak would be readily noticeable as a result of noise and, over a period of time, fuel gauge indicator movement.

- Service Procedure -- Dealers will be instructed to replace the existing T-fitting, connecting the #3 and #4 natural gas tanks, with a replacement T-fitting.

Attached is the detailed information required by the applicable portions of 49 CFR Part 573 – Defect and Non-Compliance Information Report.

Sincerely,

James P. Vondale

Attachment
02S39 5d/pcw/tab

ATTACHMENT

49 CFR Part 573 -- DEFECT INFORMATION REPORT
02S39 – 2002 MODEL YEAR FORD CROWN VICTORIA NATURAL GAS VEHICLES

Pursuant to Part 573 of Title 49 of the Code of Federal Regulations, Defect and Noncompliance Reports, Ford Motor Company submits the following information concerning a safety recall action that it is voluntarily initiating.

573.5 (c) (2) -- Potentially Affected Vehicles

2002 Model Year Ford Crown Victoria Natural Gas Vehicles built from May 10, 2001 through March 22, 2002 at the St. Thomas Assembly Plant and Transportation Design and Manufacturing Company (TDM) in Lorain, Ohio are potentially affected.

Because these vehicles are not produced in VIN order, information as to the applicability of this action to specific vehicles can best be obtained by either calling Ford's toll-free line (1-800-392-3673) or contacting a local Ford dealer, who can obtain specific information regarding the vehicles from the Ford On-line Automotive Service Information System (OASIS) database.

573.5 (c) (3) -- Estimated Population of Vehicles Potentially Affected

Approximately 574 Crown Victoria Natural Gas Vehicles in the United States.

573.5 (c) (4) -- Estimated Percentage of Affected Vehicles with the Defect Condition

All of the involved vehicles use a T-fitting with a molybdenum coated jam nut.

573.5 (c) (5) -- Description of the Defect

The T-fitting used between the #3 and #4 natural gas tanks of the upper tank assembly may contain a jam nut with a low friction molybdenum coating. When torqued to specification, this molybdenum coated jam nut may create higher tension in the neck of the T-fitting that may result in an elongation and permanent deformation of the neck. This elongation may reduce the diameter of the neck in the O-ring area, possibly extruding the O-ring and creating a leak.

There have been no reported accidents, injuries or fires attributed to this condition.

573.5 (c) (6) – Chronology of Events

On August 5, 2002 data indicated that there were fourteen reports alleging natural gas leakage from the T-fitting connecting the #3 and #4 tanks of Crown Victoria Natural Gas Vehicles. Further analysis indicated that the leak was due to a necking-down of the T-fitting in the O-ring seal area. This necking-down condition is the result of a coating applied by a supplier to the T-fitting jam nut. This coating resulted in higher tension and permanent deformation of the T-fitting in the O-ring seal area.

573.5 (c) (8) – Service Program

Dealers will be instructed to replace the existing T-fitting, connecting the #3 and #4 natural gas tanks, with a replacement T-fitting.

There will be no charge to owners for this service.

573.5 (c) (9) – Press statement and Dealer/Owner Letters

Ford does not plan to make a formal public statement concerning the subject matter of this action. A copy of the Notification letters to dealers and owners from Ford will be forwarded when available.

573.5 (c) (11) -- Recall Number

Ford has assigned recall number 02S39 to this action.